

# Refuse and reject

## Learner workbook

Decline an action or turn down an offer.

## Understand the distinction

Refuse can take to + verb: I refused to sign. It can also take an offer or request: refuse an invitation. Reject commonly takes a noun naming something not accepted: reject a proposal, reject an application.

Do not use reject to do for declining an action. Either verb can sound strong depending on context. Decline is often a courteous choice for an invitation. State a reason or an alternative when it helps the conversation, without inventing one.

## Compare the patterns

### **ACTION**

She refused to sign the form.

Refuse takes a to-infinitive.

### **PROPOSAL**

They rejected the proposal.

Reject takes the proposal as its object.

### **INVITATION**

Thank you, but I must decline.

A courteous way to turn down an invitation.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

## Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Complete: He refused \_\_\_ answer.

A. from

B. for

C. to

2. Choose the correction: They rejected to meet us.

A. They refused meet us.

B. They rejected meeting to us.

C. They refused to meet us.

3. Can refuse take a noun?

A. No. Refuse must always take a to-infinitive.

B. Yes: refuse an invitation or refuse help.

C. Yes, but only the noun answer.

## Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. You cannot attend an event and have given no reason. Which reply declines politely without inventing one?

- A. Thank you for inviting me. I look forward to joining you.
- B. Thank you for inviting me, but I cannot join because I am ill.
- C. Thank you for inviting me, but I cannot join you this time.

### Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

### Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

## Answers and explanation

### 1. C. to

Use refuse to do something.

### 2. C. They refused to meet us.

Reject does not take this to-infinitive pattern.

### 3. B. Yes: refuse an invitation or refuse help.

Its patterns are broader than refuse to do.

### 4. C. Thank you for inviting me, but I cannot join you this time.

This declines courteously without adding an unsupported explanation.

### Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: [englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-41.html](https://englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-41.html)